

The Cost of Prestige

To be clear, I'm not completely against private schools, and someone who wants to go to one and who can *afford* it should. I've got no problem with that at all. However, let's understand what I mean by *afford*. That means the student has the cash or scholarships to pay the tuition and other expenses without student loans and without completely destroying his or her financial life in the process. If that's you, great! Go do it. However, most of us wouldn't qualify. According to CNN Money, the average all-in cost for a private school is around \$45,370 per year, which includes tuition, room and board, and other expenses.¹² Let's compare those costs to the average state school. The average cost of tuition, fees, and room and board for a student at an in-state university is \$20,090.¹³ That means the private school education costs more than twice as much as the state school! For what? The same degree with a different school seal stamped on it?

Of course, grants and scholarships can bring college costs down for most families. The average *true* cost of an all-in private school education is \$26,080 per year, compared to \$14,210 per year for an in-state degree. There's still a huge price gap between the two, but it starts to make college look easier for most families to manage. I want you and your kids to set yourselves up to win by getting a solid education; I just don't want you to break the bank or bury yourself under a mountain of student loans to make it possible. In fact, spending your first two years at a community college can give you a great start, and you can do that for less than \$8,000 a year on average.¹⁴ Plus, some states now offer free—yes, *free*—community college tuition to in-state residents, which means you can get a huge head start on your education while you're working to save tuition money for years three and four at a different school.

Planning ahead and setting reasonable expectations for where you go to school can enable you to earn your bachelor's degree with absolutely no student loans hanging over your head. That's the best way I know to get